

Mav and the Ghostly Rock-n-Roll Ritual

Maverick was buzzing with excitement as his parents loaded the SUV for a weekend trip to Sacramento. The highlight? Tickets to see the legendary rock band **Ghost** at the Golden 1 Center.

"Check the trunk, Dad!" Mav shouted. "Make sure there are no beavers, ghosts, or stinky genies hiding in the spare tire well!"

"It's just us, Mav," his dad laughed. "The Professor is probably still in the rose bed at the park."

Mav breathed a sigh of relief. They hit the road, passing through Lodi. Everything was peaceful until a muffled, high-pitched voice echoed from the glove compartment.

"Maverick! The torque on this engine is respectable, but the shock absorbers are suffering from a chronic lack of structural integrity! We are bouncing at a frequency that is offensive to my felt kidneys!"

The glove box popped open. The Professor Bucktooth doll tumbled out, covered in napkins and a stray packet of honey mustard.

"Professor?!" Mav yelled. "How did you even fit in there? You're a triple-stuffed plushie!"

"I am a master of spatial optimization, Maverick! Now, drive faster! I have heard rumors that this 'Papa Emeritus' fellow wears a very structurally impressive hat, and I must audit its weight distribution!"

They reached Sacramento and parked near the Golden 1 Center. The Professor insisted on being carried in Mav's hoodie pocket, wearing a tiny, hand-drawn "Ghoulette" mask he had fashioned out of a coffee filter.

The arena was packed with fans in black robes and face paint. As the lights dimmed and the band took the stage amidst a cloud of incense and heavy metal riffs, the Professor couldn't contain himself.

"Maverick! Look at those pyrotechnics! The heat-to-oxygen ratio is a disaster waiting to happen! And those stage lights? They are suspended by cables that look like they were braided by a drunk squirrel!"

Before Mav could grab him, the Bucktooth doll launched himself out of the pocket and began scuttling across the heads of the fans in the front row like a furry, sticky athlete. He leaped onto the stage right in the middle of *'Square Hammer'*.

The music screeched to a halt as the Professor grabbed a spare microphone.

"CITIZENS OF SACRAMENTO!" the doll squeaked, his voice amplified through the massive speakers. "I am **The Timber Titan**, and I am here to report that this stage setup is a FOUNDATIONAL TRAVESTY! The lead singer's miter is tilting three degrees to the left! The incense is clogging the HVAC system! Your souls may be lost, but your building permits must be in order!"

The crowd stared in stunned silence. Suddenly, a familiar figure in a grimy trenchcoat stepped out from the stage wings, holding a mop. It was **Taffy Stamburger**.

"Kid's right," Taffy rasped into his own headset. "The floor is sticky, and the structural resonance of that bass guitar is giving me a migraine. Also, the popcorn is overpriced. I'm starting a union."

"Taffy?! You're the janitor here?!" Mav screamed from the floor.

The lead singer, Papa Emeritus IV, looked down at the tiny, syrup-stained beaver doll. Instead of being angry, he let out a flamboyant laugh and struck a pose. "A beaver of the cloth! A furry architect of the abyss! I find your critique... *exquisite*."

Suddenly, the drums kicked back in with a funky beat. The Professor, caught up in the rhythm, began to perform a high-speed, tail-thumping breakdance. He spun on his button-nose, his felt tail blurring into a circle.

The crowd went wild. "BEAVER! BEAVER! BEAVER!" they chanted.

Papa Emeritus gestured to the front row. "Bring the boy! Bring the architect's apprentice to the stage!"

Mav was hoisted up by two security guards. He stood next to the lead singer and the dancing doll, illuminated by a thousand purple spotlights.

"Maverick!" the doll yelled over the roar of the crowd. "I have analyzed the lead singer's vocal cords! They have the tensile strength of high-grade copper wire! He is structurally sound!"

Mav laughed, grabbing a tambourine and joining the dance. "You're a maniac, Professor! But you're the best roadie in the business!"

The night ended with the Professor, Mav, and Taffy Stamburger sharing a giant tub of "Ghost-themed" nachos in the dressing room. Taffy had managed to steal three "Nameless Ghoul" masks and was trying to see if they would fit a walrus.

As they drove home, the Professor fell asleep on Mav's lap, clutching a signed setlist.

"Toodaloo," the doll whispered in its sleep. "The miter... it needed... more... glue..."

Mav leaned back, covered in glitter and nacho cheese, deciding that even a rock concert in the capital wasn't safe from the glorious, absurd justice of Professor Bucktooth.

